



WRITERS' GUIDE

A psychological thriller in three seasons

Sallow Creek, Arkansas — 2001–2008

CONFIDENTIAL

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1. WHAT THIS DOCUMENT IS

This is the rulebook for writing Held Still. It defines the show's tone, visual language, character voices, and the boundaries within which every episode must operate. It is not a story document — season arcs, episode breakdowns, and plot architecture live separately. This guide answers a single question: when you sit down to write a scene of this show, how should it feel?

Pin this to your wall. Refer to it every time you're unsure whether something belongs. If a scene you've written feels like it could appear in another thriller, something has gone wrong.

2. THE GOVERNING PRINCIPLE

This show trusts the audience.

It never holds their hand. It never points at something and says “this is the scary bit.” It presents Robi’s life as he lives it — and lets the audience feel the horror of how ordinary it all seems to him. The restraint is what makes Held Still different from every other show in this space.

Every creative decision flows from this principle. If you find yourself writing a scene that tells the audience what to feel — through music, camera behaviour, dialogue, or pacing — you have broken the show.

3. TONE RULES — THE THREE PROHIBITIONS

These are non-negotiable. Every writer, director, and department head must internalise them.

3.1 No Horror Signaling

Most shows about kidnapping or captivity borrow from the horror genre. They use dark hallways, creaking doors, shadows moving in the background — visual shortcuts that scream “something bad is about to happen” or “this person is dangerous.” Think of any serial killer film where a character walks down into a basement and the whole screen goes dark and blue.

Held Still does the opposite. When Robi goes to the basement, it should feel like a boy going to check on a sick family member. The camera doesn’t change its behaviour. The lighting doesn’t shift to something sinister. The house doesn’t suddenly feel different. The horror comes from the audience realising that this feels routine to him, not from the show dressing it up as scary.

✓ **DO:** Write: “Robi opens the basement door, flicks on the light, and heads downstairs carrying a tray.”

✗ **DON’T:** Write: “Robi descends into the darkness below.”

3.2 No Lingering Shots

A lingering shot is when the camera stays on something longer than it needs to — a character’s face after they’ve said something disturbing, a closed door after someone walks through it, a hand gripping a railing. It’s a classic technique for building tension or telling the audience “that moment was important, you should feel something about it.”

In Held Still, the camera behaves normally. If Robi says something chilling, the scene moves on — the way life moves on. There is no pause that says “did you catch that?” to the viewer. This forces the audience to do the emotional work themselves. Instead of the show telling them “that was disturbing,” they sit with their own reaction.

✓ **DO:** Keep scenes moving at the pace of real life. One thing follows another.

✗ **DON’T:** Write stage directions like “Beat. Robi stares at the closed door.” or “A long pause. Eleanor searches his face.”

3.3 No Score Cues Telegraphing Danger

In most thrillers, the music does enormous work — a low drone starts when something bad is coming, strings tighten during tense moments, a sudden sharp note hits when something is revealed. The music tells you to be afraid before anything has happened.

Held Still's score never does this. It doesn't warn the audience. It doesn't swell during emotional moments or go dark during basement scenes.

Instead, the show's sound design is built around isolated mundane audio — the most powerful sonic moments come from ordinary, everyday sounds heard in silence. A kettle boiling. A clock ticking. A spoon against a bowl. A door closing. The absence of music makes these small sounds feel enormous.

When Robi is in the basement with a captive, you don't hear ominous music — you hear his breathing, the creak of a chair, maybe the muffled sound of Eleanor's TV upstairs. That silence is far more unsettling than any score could be.

✓ **DO:** Write the specific sounds the audience hears: "The only sound is the drip of the faucet." or "Upstairs, the TV plays a weather report."

✗ **DON'T:** Write "tension builds" or "the mood shifts." Let concrete sounds replace what music would normally do.

3.4 The Underlying Philosophy

What you don't see is always more frightening than what you see. What you don't hear is always more unsettling than what you hear. What the show doesn't tell you is always more powerful than what it explains. This applies to every element — performance, camera, sound, editing, and above all, the writing.

4. EPISODE STRUCTURE

4.1 The Slow Burn

Held Still is a slow burn. This is not a phrase we use lightly or aspirationally — it is the structural identity of the show. Information arrives in drips. The audience's experience should mirror the captives' experience: long stretches of controlled quiet punctuated by sudden, devastating reveals. Build, build, build — and then the ground shifts beneath you.

Think of it as psychological pressure. Each episode adds weight incrementally. When a major reveal arrives — and they are spaced carefully across the season — it should feel like an explosion, not because the moment itself is loud, but because everything before it was so precisely calibrated.

4.2 Cold Opens

Every episode opens cold — a scene before the title sequence that drops us into Robi's world and his internal state. This is our ritual entry point. The cold open should always sit with Robi and tell us where he is psychologically at this moment. It could be mundane. It could be quietly horrifying. But it is always his.

No flash-forwards. Ever. The audience discovers everything in real time. Flash-forwards undermine the slow-burn philosophy by letting the viewer see where the pressure leads before they've felt it build.

4.3 Title Sequence

The show has a title sequence. Its design and content will be developed separately, but writers should account for its placement after the cold open in every episode.

4.4 Parallel Storylines

Episodes cut between multiple storylines. The primary thread is always Robi — his internal world, his actions, his rationalizations. Around him, we weave Ryan's investigation and the captives' experience. The balance shifts episode to episode depending on the story's needs, but Robi is always the centre of gravity.

Some episodes may lean heavily into one storyline — an episode that spends extended time in the basement, or one that follows Ryan as he gets close to something. But we always return to Robi.

4.5 Episode Endings

Episodes do not end on traditional cliffhangers — no gunshots, no screams, no doors slamming. Instead, they end on a feeling of unease. Something has been building throughout the episode, and the final scene leaves it unresolved — not with a dramatic hook, but with a quiet discomfort that stays with the viewer.

The resolution or explanation of that build-up comes at the beginning of the following episode, after Robi's cold open. This creates a rhythm: unease carries you into the next episode, and the opening rewards your return before the next layer of pressure begins.

4.6 Time Within Episodes

There is no fixed rule for how much time passes within a single episode. It could be hours, a day, or several days, depending on what the story requires. Each season covers approximately two years, so episodes need the flexibility to compress or expand time as needed. The only requirement is clarity — the audience should always know roughly when they are.

4.7 Pacing Reference

The closest structural comparison is *Dexter* — a protagonist with an inner voice, parallel investigation, and a dual life the audience is complicit in. *Held Still* runs slower than *Dexter*. The psychological intensity, measured per minute of screen time, should be significantly higher. If *Dexter* is a ten on the pacing scale, *Held Still* is a seven or eight — but on psychological immersion, it is aiming for the intensity of *You* multiplied tenfold.

5. POINT OF VIEW — WHAT THE AUDIENCE KNOWS

5.1 The Mystery Principle

The audience discovers information as the characters discover it. This is a mystery, not a dramatic irony. We are not watching from above — we are embedded alongside the characters, piecing things together at the same pace they do.

The pilot does not reveal everything. It gives clues. The first season is a slow reveal of Robi's world and what he is doing. Major revelations are spaced to land as genuine shocks — not because they are loud, but because the quiet build-up made them inevitable and devastating at the same time.

5.2 Multiple Perspectives

Although the audience discovers alongside the characters, we do move between perspectives within each episode. We see what Ryan is doing in his investigation. We go inside the captives' heads when Robi is not with them. We see Eleanor at her practice, Ashley at school, Pruitt in his office.

The key distinction: each perspective gives us only what that character knows. Ryan's scenes show us his progress, which builds tension because we can see the investigation closing in while Robi cannot. Jessica's scenes alone in the basement show us her fear, her strategy, her internal calculations — while Robi sees only what she chooses to let him see.

5.3 The Audience's Inner Conflict

The show's deepest achievement should be that the audience wants everyone to win — and that is impossible. They feel for Robi even though he is the perpetrator. They root for Ryan and the investigation. They ache for the people in the basement. These sympathies are irreconcilable, and the show never resolves the tension between them. Writers must hold all three in balance. If the audience stops caring about any one of the three sides, the show fails.

5.4 Binge Architecture

This show is designed to be binge-watched. Every episode should create the compulsion to start the next one — not through cheap hooks, but through genuine psychological investment. The audience should feel that stopping mid-season would be like leaving a conversation half-finished.

6. CHARACTER VOICES

6.1 Robi (Robert) Marsh

Intelligence and Masking

Robi is significantly more intelligent than his peers. He has been studying medicine from Eleanor's textbooks and has developed a vocabulary and analytical capacity far beyond what is expected of a boy his age. However, he is acutely aware of the need to blend in. In public — at school, with friends, with adults — he deliberately performs a version of himself that is slightly smarter than average but never conspicuously so. He dials his intelligence down, not up.

If you asked one of Robi's friends or acquaintances to describe him, they would say: "Yeah, Robi, I've known him a long time. He's a really nice guy." And then they would pause and add: "But there's something about him. Something I can't quite work out." That is exactly the impression he should leave on the audience too.

With the Captives — His "Guests"

Robi does not use the words "prisoner," "captive," or any language that acknowledges wrongdoing. He calls them guests. This is not a performance for their benefit — he genuinely believes it. In his mind, these are people who he needs to keep close, people who should not be allowed to leave and abandon him. The word "guest" reflects his authentic understanding of the relationship.

With Jessica, he is warm, accommodating, and attentive. He talks about his day, asks how she is feeling, tries to provide comfort. This warmth is genuine and deeply disturbing — the dissonance between his care and the reality of her situation is the engine of every basement scene with her.

With Derek, his tone is different. Not cruel, but sarcastic. He sees Derek as someone who needs to be improved — taught to be a better person. He has taken on the role of educator, and there is a patronising edge to his care. Derek does not receive the same gentleness as Jessica.

Robi will never acknowledge out loud that what he is doing is wrong, because he does not believe it is wrong. He has guests. He would like them to stay. He worries about their wellbeing. Any script that has Robi questioning his own morality or showing guilt is breaking the character.

The Internal Outbursts

This is one of the show's most distinctive and important character beats, and it must be handled with extreme care.

Robi will experience moments of intense frustration — particularly when a captive questions what he is doing or pushes back against his worldview. But these are not conventional outbursts. He does not shout. He does not threaten. He does not slam things. What happens is internal: something shifts behind his eyes. He continues talking as if nothing has happened. He maintains his warmth and composure. But the captive — Jessica especially — will see it. And the audience will see it.

This is the most frightening thing about Robi: the turbulence is real, but he cannot articulate it, and he will not express it. It remains trapped inside him, visible only as a flicker. These moments should not begin until Episode 3 or 4, and they should arrive rarely enough to retain their power.

The principle at work: what you don't see is always scarier than what you see. A conventional outburst is frightening in the moment but reassuringly legible — you understand the threat. Robi's internal suppression is terrifying precisely because it is illegible. You know something is happening, but you do not know what it will become.

Inner Voice

We hear Robi's thoughts as inner voice — comparable to Dexter's internal monologue. He does not talk to himself out loud. His thoughts give us access to his rationalizations, his emotional logic, and the gap between how he sees the world and how the world actually is. This inner voice is our primary tool for understanding him.

Language Rules

Robi never curses. He speaks like a 13-year-old from a small Arkansas town in 2001, but one who reads medical textbooks privately. His public vocabulary is ordinary. His private vocabulary — in his thoughts and with his guests — is more precise and clinical, though never ostentatiously so.

6.2 Other Characters — General Principles

All characters in Held Still must be fully three-dimensional. There are no villains in the conventional sense. There are no heroes. Every character believes they are doing the right thing, and the audience should understand why — even when they disagree.

Sheriff Dale Pruitt is comic relief, but he is never stupid. He is vain, enthusiastic, loves his job and his family, and is genuinely likeable. The audience should adore him and be infuriated by him in equal measure. His apparent incompetence has a deeper explanation that is not revealed until late in the series, and writers must never undermine the later reveal by making him implausibly foolish.

Jessica Cole is the emotional anchor of the captive storyline. She is resourceful, strategic, and increasingly sophisticated in her understanding of Robi. She learns to read his internal states before anyone else does. Her blink-based communication evolves into a survival tool and eventually a means of subtle manipulation.

7. VIOLENCE, HUMOUR, AND ROMANCE

7.1 Violence

There is no blood on this show. There is no graphic physical violence. No one is shot, stabbed, beaten, or cut up on screen. This is not a show that derives tension from physical threat — it derives tension from psychological pressure.

If something physical does happen, we see its aftermath or its emotional consequence, not the act itself. The violence in *Held Still* is the violence of confinement, dependency, isolation, and control. It is quieter and more devastating than anything a weapon could do.

Writers who feel the urge to write a violent scene should ask themselves: what is the psychological equivalent of this moment? Write that instead.

7.2 Humour

Yes, there is humour in this show. It is dry, dark, and English in sensibility — the kind that makes you laugh and then feel uncomfortable about having laughed. It is never broad or slapstick.

Pruitt is the primary source of comedy, but his humour comes from character, not from jokes. His earnestness, his vanity, his baffling decision-making — these are funny because they are recognisable. The audience laughs because they know someone like him.

Robi may occasionally say something darkly funny, but he is never aware that it is funny. The humour comes from the audience's recognition of the dissonance, not from Robi performing wit.

7.3 Sex and Romance

Robi and Ashley's relationship is young love, portrayed with warmth and beauty. It should feel genuine, tender, and recognisable to anyone who remembers their first serious relationship.

The show does not need sex scenes. Intimacy is conveyed through glances, small gestures, physical proximity, and the specific quality of attention two people give each other when they are falling in love. If and when the characters do become physically intimate, it is handled with care and responsibility appropriate to the portrayal of young people.

The beauty of this relationship is also part of the show's cruelty — the audience knows what Robi is, and they must watch Ashley fall in love with someone whose reality she cannot see.

8. THE WORLD OF SALLOW CREEK

8.1 The Town

Sallow Creek is a small town in rural Arkansas with a population between 500 and 1,000. It sits in Ozark country — the kind of place where everyone knows everyone, where news travels through the grocery store before it reaches the newspaper, and where a new face draws attention.

The town is not dying, but it is not thriving either. It is comfortable in the way that places are comfortable when nothing much changes. Some families do well; others struggle. The economic spread is real but narrow — there is no true wealth and no true poverty, just degrees of getting by.

People keep to themselves but talk about each other freely. Privacy is a polite fiction. This is important for the story: in a town this small, keeping a secret of Robi's magnitude should be impossible — which makes it all the more disturbing that he manages it.

8.2 The Marsh Household

The Marshes are the town's upper class by virtue of Eleanor's medical practice, which she runs from home. They live in a two-storey house with a stairlift on the stairwell for Thomas and his wheelchair. The house is well-maintained, comfortable, and respectable. They drive a Honda Accord. Everything about the Marsh home communicates stability and quiet prosperity.

Eleanor's home office contains a computer that she uses for administration. Robi is allowed to use it for homework and has become computer-savvy, using it for research and occasionally ordering items online. This computer is a significant practical element — it is Robi's portal to information the town cannot provide.

8.3 The Cole Household

The Coles are below middle class. Jessica and Ashley's father is a farmer with a small operation that has been struggling. The family is not destitute, but money is tight, and the stress of that situation is present in the household. This economic pressure does not help matters when Jessica disappears.

8.4 Technology and Period Detail — Early 2000s

The show is set in rural Arkansas beginning in 2001. Technology is a crucial period element that affects every scene practically.

Mobile phones: Basic models only — Nokia, Motorola. Calls and texts, nothing else. No cameras, no internet. Eleanor has one as a doctor on call, which is a character detail as much as a practical one. Most people in Sallow Creek may not carry one at all.

Internet: Dial-up. Using the internet means tying up the phone line. The connection sound is a period detail worth using. Access is slow, unreliable, and feels like an event rather than a background utility.

Instant messaging: MSN Messenger is active by this period and could serve as an early form of social communication between the young characters. This is the very beginning of what will become social media — novel, exciting, and limited to whoever happens to be online at the same time.

Television: The Marsh household has a basic TV. No streaming, no on-demand. Whatever is on is what's on. This matters for ambient sound design — a weather report or a game show playing in the background is a period-specific texture.

Landlines: The primary mode of communication. Answering machines. The experience of calling someone and not reaching them and simply not knowing where they are.

The absence of modern technology is not nostalgic decoration — it is structurally important. Characters cannot track each other. They cannot Google a suspicion. They cannot text a warning. Information moves slowly, which amplifies both Robi's ability to operate undetected and Ryan's frustration in trying to find answers.

9. THE BASEMENT

The basement is the show's most distinctive and important location. Every writer must be able to picture it identically.

9.1 Dimensions and Layout

The basement measures 50 feet by 30 feet — a substantial space beneath the Marsh family home. It contains five cubicles, designated C1 through C5, each measuring 9 feet by 12 feet. Three cubicles (C1, C2, C3) are arranged in a row along one wall, with two more (C4, C5) in a second row opposite. Each cubicle contains a single bed (3 feet by 6 feet 6 inches).

A separate floor plan is attached to this guide for spatial reference.

9.2 Access

There are two access points. The internal stairway descends from inside the house — this is Robi's entry route. He enters the basement through the house so that no external observer would ever see anyone going in or out. The external bulkhead access, located at the opposite end, is permanently locked and concealed. Robi has ensured that no one would even think to look for an entrance there.

9.3 Construction and Soundproofing

The cubicle walls are constructed from drywall on timber frames. Every wall surface is covered with acoustic foam padding — the kind of studio soundproofing sponge that absorbs all ambient noise.

This detail has profound implications for both the visual and sonic texture of every basement scene. Visually, the foam gives the space a distinctive, almost alien appearance — uniform, textured, enclosing. Sonically, it creates an eerie dead silence. When nothing is happening in a cubicle, the quiet is absolute and oppressive. This kind of silence can be psychologically destabilising over time — a fact the show should lean into.

Critically, the soundproofing means the captives cannot hear each other. Each person in the basement exists in total isolation, unaware of the others. This is fundamental to Robi's control system and to the dramatic structure of the captive storyline.

9.4 Lighting

Dim single light bulbs provide the only illumination in each cubicle. The lighting is low and static. There is no way for the captives to determine whether it is day or night outside. The

disorientation this produces is part of their experience and should be written into their psychological state.

9.5 The Flip-Clock

Jessica — and Jessica alone — receives a bedside flip-clock, one of those mechanical clocks where numbered cards fall with a soft click to show the time and date. This is a special privilege, a gesture of Robi's particular care for her. It is simultaneously a kindness and a quiet cruelty — the clock tells her exactly how much time is passing, exactly how long no one has come for her.

Other captives do not receive this. The hierarchy of small comforts is part of Robi's system, whether or not he consciously frames it as control.

9.6 Sensory Environment

The basement smells damp and unpleasant. Bodily waste must be managed, and the conditions are never comfortable regardless of Robi's efforts. He does try to make the space as liveable as he can — but more for some captives than others. The disparity in how different cubicles are maintained is itself a story element.

Writers should always be specific about what a character sees, hears, and smells in the basement. The absence of normal sensory input — no daylight, no outdoor sounds, no weather, no other voices — is itself a form of violence. Write it that way.

9.7 Writing Basement Scenes

Every sound in the basement is enormous. The flip of a clock digit. A breath. A shift on the mattress. The click of the door at the top of the stairs. Because the acoustic foam absorbs everything, whatever sound does exist becomes the entire world.

This is where the show's sound design philosophy and the physical space converge. Basement scenes should be written with precise attention to specific, small sounds. Do not write "silence." Write what the silence contains.

10. THE COMMUNICATION SYSTEM

10.1 Blink Communication

Robi's captives are restrained in a way that limits their physical movement and speech. The primary communication channel he establishes is a blink-based yes/no system. One blink for yes, two for no (or a variation to be finalised in the pilot).

This system is simple by design — it gives Robi the illusion of connection and care while maintaining total control over the terms of the conversation. He asks the questions. They answer. The power dynamic is embedded in the mechanism itself.

10.2 Jessica's Strategic Use

Jessica learns to weaponise the blink system. Over time, she uses it not just to respond but to guide Robi's questions, to feed him the answers she wants him to hear, and to subtly manipulate his behaviour. This evolution — from passive respondent to active strategist — is one of the show's most important character arcs and should be developed gradually across the first two seasons.

10.3 Morse Code — Future Development

The possibility of evolving the communication system to include Morse code is being explored. If viable, this would represent a significant escalation in the captives' ability to communicate independently of Robi and could become a turning point in the power dynamic. This element is flagged for development and is not yet confirmed for inclusion.

11. FORMAL DEVICES

11.1 Captive Voiceover

The captives' inner experience is conveyed through voiceover that operates on a day-to-day level — their thoughts, fears, calculations, and emotional states as they live through captivity. This is distinct from Robi's inner voice in both tone and function. Where Robi's thoughts rationalise, the captives' thoughts reckon.

11.2 Mind-Space Sequences

At emotional peaks, the show employs heightened visual sequences that take us inside a character's psychological experience. These are not dreams and not fantasies — they are visual representations of interior states, and they operate with their own visual grammar distinct from the show's naturalistic baseline.

These sequences should be used sparingly. Their power comes from contrast with the show's otherwise restrained visual language. If they become routine, they lose their impact.

11.3 Robi's Inner Voice

As discussed in the character section, Robi's inner monologue serves as the audience's primary access to his psychology. It should feel intimate, conversational, and chillingly reasonable. The audience should find themselves nodding along to his logic before catching themselves. That moment of self-recognition — “why did I almost agree with him?” — is the show's most unsettling effect.

12. TONAL REFERENCE SCENES

[TO BE ADDED — Specific scenes from existing shows and films that capture the tone, pace, and feeling Held Still is aiming for. These references are being compiled and will be inserted in a future revision of this guide.]

REMINDER: *Reference scenes from other shows/films are still needed for this section. These should be specific moments — not whole shows — that capture what Held Still should feel like, even if they come from completely different genres.*

13. THE RULES AT A GLANCE

- ✓ **DO:** Trust the audience to feel without being told what to feel.
- ✓ **DO:** Write specific sounds instead of mood descriptions.
- ✓ **DO:** Keep Robi's warmth with captives genuine and undisturbed.
- ✓ **DO:** Make every character three-dimensional and sympathetic.
- ✓ **DO:** Write the basement with precise sensory detail.
- ✓ **DO:** Let information arrive slowly, in drips.
- ✓ **DO:** Build to reveals — don't telegraph them.
- ✓ **DO:** Portray young love with warmth and beauty.
- ✓ **DO:** Find the humour in character, not in jokes.
- ✓ **DO:** Write Robi's internal turbulence as something seen only in his eyes.

- ✗ **DON'T:** Use horror genre signaling — dark hallways, blue lighting, ominous framing.
- ✗ **DON'T:** Write lingering shots, meaningful pauses, or loaded silences in stage directions.
- ✗ **DON'T:** Use score cues to telegraph danger or build tension.
- ✗ **DON'T:** Show graphic violence or blood.
- ✗ **DON'T:** Have Robi acknowledge wrongdoing or use words like "captive" or "prisoner."
- ✗ **DON'T:** Have Robi curse.
- ✗ **DON'T:** Write conventional outbursts — shouting, threatening, physical aggression.
- ✗ **DON'T:** Use flash-forwards.
- ✗ **DON'T:** Give the audience information before the characters have it.
- ✗ **DON'T:** Let any of the three storylines (Robi / investigation / captives) become unsympathetic.

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